

Beneficiaries, Name Changes, and Wills

After the wedding, there are several financial issues you should take care of right away. Go through the documentation for your retirement plans, life insurance policies, bank accounts, and investment accounts. If you want your spouse to be the beneficiary, file change-of-beneficiary forms. Most private pension plans require that your spouse be named as primary beneficiary unless a waiver is executed by the spouse. Also look for accounts you want to add your spouse's name to as joint owner, or where you need to change the name of the person to notify in an emergency. If one of you owns property, decide whether you want to change the deed to include both your names. It should be noted that property acquired before the marriage would not be considered marital property in the event of a divorce. However by changing the form of ownership to include both names you have converted separate property to marital property.



If you have a complicated financial situation or a large net worth, consult an estate-planning attorney about ways to protect your estate from higher taxes if one of you dies.

If you change your name when you get married, apply for a new social security card, vehicle title, and driver's license in your new name. Notify banks, insurance companies, brokerages, and others about your name change. Be aware that if you add your name to your spouse's existing credit card, you'll be equally responsible for the debt that he or she brought into the marriage.

Have a will drawn up, or if you already have one, have it updated or rewritten. If one of you has children from a previous relationship, it's especially important to spell out guardianship and custody issues.